CHAPTER 4

S Y R I A O F T H E A R A B S

ARABIC SOCIETY AND PALESTINE

Palestine does not hold the same unique position in general Arabic consciousness as it does in religious Judaism or nationalist Zionism. For the general Arabic world, Palestine is one corner of the great province of Syria, of which the center lies at Damascus rather than Jerusalem. This historic Syrian province runs from Alexandretta to Sinai. It includes both the narrow coastal areas now within the political boundaries of the Lebanon and Palestine and the broader territories now within the boundaries of Syria and Transjordan. The historic Syria, in turn, is only one of the provinces of the Arab world, of lesser religious significance than the Hejas and no more uniquely expressive of Arab political aspirations than are Iraq, Egypt, or the States of the Arabian peninsula.

Yet, to the Arabs of Palestine, the country is as uniquely their homeland as to any Zionist Jew. For nine centuries, from the expulsion of the Byzantines to the coming of the Turks, Palestine was -- at least in part -- under Arab rule. For perhaps ten centuries (from about three centuries after the first Arab conquest) the majority of its people have spoken the Arabic language. They have made their lives in Palestine and buried their dead in its soil. They are not rootless people, to be lightly shipped off to any other country. With the awakening of nationalist consciousness, they have come to feel themselves Arabs -- but Palestine Arabs.

ISLAMIC ORIGINS AND PALESTINE

Islam is not primarily a development from Arab paganism. Its principal roots are Jewish and Christian, and like these older religions it has many profound associations with the soil of Palestine. "Mohammedanism," said G. F. Moore, "owes its existence to the impression Jewish and, in smaller degree, Christian ideas made